

A SPECIAL EDITION OF

MERIDIAN

The Men Who Build Singapore — an ultra deep dive



Singapore public housing at night — representative of the flats this workforce builds, not a specific site or worker. Source: Wikimedia Commons.

THE DEBT

A recruitment fee that can run to twenty times a month's wage — and the casework showing what happens to a man sent home before he clears it

THE LEDGER

Workplace deaths in Singapore rose to 43 in 2024, construction the worst-hit sector — and no public table says how many of the dead were Bangladeshi

THE UNDERCURRENT

A construction worker kept a diary on his phone after each shift. It won Singapore's Book of the Year for non-fiction

THIS SPECIAL EDITION

The Second Migrant-Labour Book — Debt, Not Vice, This Time

- p3–4** The Pipeline — the dalal who calls himself a helper, the BMET card that makes it official, and a fee that can outrun a year’s wages before it’s even booked
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FROM THE DESK

"Everyone insists that migration is fundamentally a matter of economics, and yet the greatest migrations of history have been driven by acute desperation."

— **Suketu Mehta**, *This Land Is Our Land: An Immigrant’s Manifesto* (2019)¹

Mehta wrote that about desperation as the migrant’s engine; this book found a quieter, more contractual version of it — a fee financed by a sold plot of land (p3), a job that can be cancelled the day a man asks to be paid what he is owed (p9), and a debt that, per Singapore’s own courts this April, an employer cannot simply declare paid (p8). This is the second book in the reader’s migrant-labour series, and it holds the same rule as the first: the subject is the men and the system, reported with dignity, never as a pity portrait or a policy brochure.

THE STRIP — THE SYSTEM, AT A GLANCE

MEASURE	READING
Bangladeshi first-time recruitment fee	Reported \$6,800–\$17,000, per case
Typical repayment window, per TWC2	"At least 16 months"
Singapore workplace deaths, 2024	43, up from 36 in 2023
Construction share of those deaths	20 of 43
Bangladesh remittances, FY2025–26	Record \$35.56bn (provisional)
Share moving through hundi (informal)	Reported 22%–51%
MOM 2024 survey, migrant satisfaction	95.3%, self-reported

Figures hedged throughout; see per-page footnotes.²

SOURCES 1. Suketu Mehta, *This Land Is Our Land: An Immigrant’s Manifesto*, Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2019. 2. See per-page sourcing throughout; several primary government and NGO pages were unreachable from this book’s research sandbox this edition (network egress restriction) — a limitation disclosed openly rather than papered over, see p24.

THE PIPELINE • RECRUITMENT

The Broker Who Calls Himself a Helper

A man in a sending district arranges a Singapore construction job for a fee he calls a service charge, not a debt. How much of the money above him is real and how much is markup is the first honest question this book has to hold open.

On paper, the system is orderly. Bangladesh's Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training (BMET), under the Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, licenses the recruiting agencies that may legally send a worker abroad — a reported 2,136 valid agencies as of recent counts, rising to a record 2,646 after 252 new licences were approved in a single month, January 2026.¹ A worker registers through BMET's online clearance system, passes a medical screen and a mandatory pre-departure orientation, and leaves with what amounts to Bangladesh's own exit paperwork tied to his Singapore employer's approval.² Below that formal layer sits the dalal — an informal, often locally trusted sub-agent, frequently a relative or a fellow villager's contact, who does the actual matchmaking between a Singapore job order and a man willing to travel. He is rarely BMET-licensed himself; he works through, or alongside, a licensed agency's name.

Bangladesh's national umbrella body for licensed agencies, the Bangladesh Association of International Recruiting Agencies (BAIRA), has existed since 1984 and functions as the trade's political voice.³ It is also, on the country's own anti-corruption record, not clean: in September 2025 Bangladesh's Anti-Corruption Commission filed cases against more than thirty individuals linked to thirteen recruiting agencies, several holding BAIRA leadership positions, and separately pursued owners of some sixty BAIRA-linked agencies over an alleged embezzlement running into billions of taka from hundreds of thousands of Malaysia-bound workers.⁴ Those cases concern the Malaysia corridor specifically, not Singapore — this book states that distinction plainly rather than borrowing the number's weight for a claim about a different route. What they establish is systemic: the licensing regime that is supposed to be

the safeguard has itself been the subject of the state's own fraud prosecutions.

A dalal who calls himself a helper is not lying about the relationship. He is describing exactly how much leverage it gives him.

On which districts actually feed Singapore's construction sites specifically, this book found real evidence but not a clean answer. Cumilla, Chattogram, Brahmanbaria, Tangail and Dhaka district are named across BMET-adjacent reporting as Bangladesh's largest labour-exporting districts overall, across every destination country combined — not a Singapore-specific breakdown.⁵ Anecdotal sources point to Tangail and Munshiganj as districts with long histories of Singapore construction migration reaching back to the late 1990s.⁶ No authoritative government table naming Singapore's actual top sending districts surfaced, and none is claimed here.

THE RECORD

Academic framing worth taking seriously: sociologist Md Mizanur Rahman's study of Bangladesh–Singapore migration argues the real decision-making unit is not the individual worker but the *bari* — the extended family homestead — weighing a mix of economic need and social status in sending a son abroad, which is one reason a family will mortgage land for a fee before the job is even confirmed.⁷

THE SCEPTIC

Several lower-authority Singapore recruitment-agency websites offered tidy, specific-sounding steps for the BMET clearance process; this book leans on BMET's and BCA's own pages and named press reporting instead, and flags the agency-site material as unverified colour, not fact.

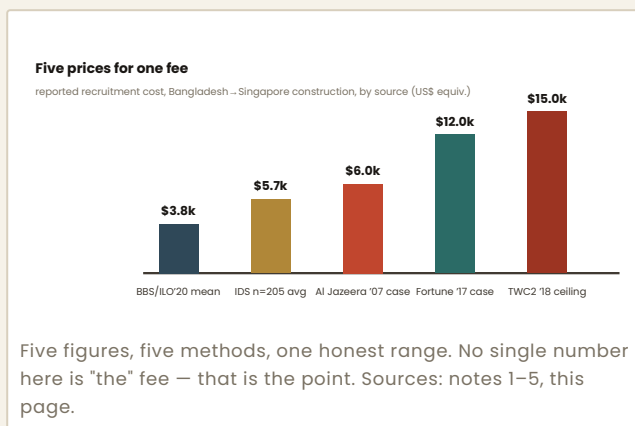
SOURCES 1. Dhaka Tribune, "Hidden costs of migration entrap Bangladeshi workers"; The Daily Star, Bangladeshi migrant-worker coverage (Jan 2026 licensing count). 2. BMET online clearance system and Pre-Departure Orientation requirement, cross-referenced against BCA's Overseas Trade Testing framework — see p7. 3. Bangladesh Association of International Recruiting Agencies (BAIRA), founded 1984. 4. Anti-Corruption Commission (Bangladesh) enforcement actions, September 2025, reported against BAIRA-linked agencies on the Malaysia corridor — SINGLE-SOURCED via search aggregation, not independently opened this edition. 5. District emigration-ranking figures reported without a single clean primary attribution this edition; treated as indicative, not authoritative. 6. Munshiganj Singapore-construction-migration history, "Waiting for Lorry" migrant-worker oral-history project; Tangail Little India gathering point — SINGLE-SOURCED, unconfirmed. 7. Md Mizanur Rahman, *Bangladeshi Migration to Singapore: A Process-Oriented Approach*, Springer, 2017.

THE PIPELINE • THE FEE

A Number Five Studies Can't Agree On — And What That Disagreement Means

Every credible source that has tried to price a Bangladeshi worker's route into Singapore construction work has landed somewhere different. This book prints the spread rather than a false single figure, because the spread is itself the finding: nobody, including Singapore's own labour ministry, actually knows the number.

Al Jazeera documented a Bangladeshi worker in Singapore who paid \$6,000 for a shipyard job and work permit in 2007, defrauded by an agent who took the money and the passport.¹ A decade later, Fortune profiled Mohammad Ashadul Islam, who sold his father's land and fish farm and borrowed the equivalent of roughly US\$12,000 (S\$17,000) across multiple agencies for a construction job that laid him off before he could repay it.² TWC2's own 2018 research put Bangladeshi construction fees at up to \$15,000 in some cases — sometimes twenty times a month's basic salary.³ Set against those individual cases, two larger surveys land lower: Bangladesh's own 2020 Cost of Migration Survey, run with ILO support, found a mean recruitment cost of roughly Tk 416,789 (about US\$3,800) across all destination countries, against average monthly migrant earnings of just US\$236⁴; and a quantitative fieldwork survey of 205 Bangladeshi construction workers in Singapore specifically found an average placement fee of SGD 7,256 (about US\$5,660).⁵ Singapore's own Ministry of Manpower has said plainly it does not track the figure systematically, because most of the fee is paid inside Bangladesh, outside its legal reach — its only public data point is a 2019 set of ad hoc worker interviews putting typical fees at "S\$2,000 to S\$10,000," a range wide enough to contain nearly every number above it.⁶



The financing is more consistent than the fee. Reporting on affected families describes 67% of migrant workers taking loans, 24% selling land, and 23% mortgaging property to raise the money — the categories overlap because families commonly combine methods.⁷ Bangladesh maintains a dedicated Probashi Kallyan Bank offering migration loans at a reported 8%, but its reach is described in reporting as inadequate to real demand, pushing many families toward rural moneylenders charging 60–100% interest.⁸ One concrete reform effort exists worth naming: a pilot channel run by the Asia Philanthropy Circle with the Bangladeshi NGO BRAC, letting a small number of Singapore employers recruit construction labour directly through a vetted, non-profit route explicitly designed to avoid the standard fee stack.⁹

THE SCEPTIC

A widely repeated figure — "Bangladeshi workers pay an average of \$5,560 to reach Singapore, versus \$2,680 for Filipino or Indonesian workers" — could not be traced to one clean, checkable primary source in this book's research. It is plausible, it is consistent with the range above, and it is not printed here as a stated fact.

SOURCES 1. Al Jazeera, "Agents fleece Bangladeshi migrants," 25 Mar 2007. 2. Fortune, "Singapore: Bangladeshi Migrant Workers Trapped in Debt," 19 Jun 2017. 3. TWC2, "Recruitment cost in some cases about 20 times monthly salary," 22 Nov 2018. 4. Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics / ILO, Cost of Migration Survey 2020. 5. Grace Baey, "Migration and Precarious Work," Migrating out of Poverty working paper WP26, Institute of Development Studies. 6. Singapore Ministry of Manpower, written parliamentary answer to MP Leon Perera, 8 May 2023. 7. The Business Standard, "Despite laws and pledges, migrant workers remain prey to exploitation," 17 May 2025. 8. Same source; Probashi Kallyan Bank rate per government-adjacent secondary reporting, not independently confirmed against the bank's own published rate card this edition. 9. Devpolicy Blog (Development Policy Centre, ANU), "From dalal to legitimate service providers? Bangladesh migration reform," 2 May 2024.

THE DEBT · THE ARC

How Long It Takes, and What Happens If You Don't Make It

TWC2's own casework puts the fastest honest repayment at "at least sixteen months." A man sent home before that clock runs out does not simply lose a job. He goes home owing money for one he no longer has.

TWC2's 2018 research on Bangladeshi construction workers found that, on the fee levels described on the previous two pages, workers "typically require at least sixteen months" of work simply to clear the recruitment debt before a single dollar becomes theirs to keep or send home.¹ A more recent, sharply specific case: TWC2's November 2024 casework describes a worker referred to as Baitob, who arrived in April that year owing \$8,000 on a basic monthly salary of \$384, hoping to clear the debt within eighteen months to two years — and whose employer, TWC2 found, was making salary deductions his own work-pass approval did not authorise and he had never consented to in writing.² Nationally, Bangladesh's 2022 Labour Force Survey — using the ILO/KNOMAD recruitment-cost indicator aligned to UN Sustainable Development Goal target 10.7.1 — found recruitment costs equal to roughly 14.6 months of a worker's income on average, 15.1 months for men specifically.³ None of these figures is Singapore-construction-specific and Singapore-only; they are presented together because, read side by side, they describe the same order of magnitude from three independent angles.

The debt's second act is what happens when the job ends before the debt does. TWC2 has documented this repeatedly and specifically. Mollah Sharif paid \$4,200 to an acquaintance acting as an informal job broker; when his job ended prematurely he faced debt collectors within three days, before he dared file the salary claim he was owed.⁴ Azizul, injured on site, was given a medical certificate his employer refused to honour; threatened with repatriation, he

was eventually placed on a Special Pass — barred from working, permitted only to remain — and survived on \$1,000 across fifteen months while his case crawled through the system.⁵ TWC2's broader pattern claim, consistent across its casework though not traced here to one single verbatim source: an employer facing a salary claim will almost always cancel the Work Permit and decline consent for a transfer, making repatriation the default outcome of asking to be paid what one is owed.⁶

16 mo.

TWC2'S FLOOR ESTIMATE, TIME TO CLEAR A FIRST-TIME BANGLADESHI RECRUITMENT DEBT

\$8,000

BAITOB'S RECRUITMENT DEBT ON ARRIVAL, APRIL 2024, AGAINST A \$384 BASIC MONTHLY WAGE

THE ARGUMENT, IN ACADEMIC FORM

The clearest scholarly account of why this matters is Platt, Baey, Yeoh, Khoo and Lam's 2017 study of debt among Bangladeshi construction workers and Indonesian domestic workers in Singapore: debt runs on a spectrum from quiet, absorbed obligation to loud, quantifiable crisis, and the fee itself — combined with low wages, weak bargaining power, and gaps in enforcement — is the mechanism through which vulnerability gets built in, not merely revealed.⁷

TWC2's own institutional logic offers a further, uncomfortable argument: simply raising wages for Bangladeshi workers would likely not fix the debt problem alone, since agents would raise fees to match, pushing the same trap one rung higher rather than closing it.⁸

SOURCES 1. TWC2, "Recruitment cost in some cases about 20 times monthly salary," 22 Nov 2018. 2. TWC2, "Ever seen negative salary? We just did," 26 Nov 2024. 3. ILO, "Statistics for SDG indicator 10.7.1: Measuring recruitment costs," citing Bangladesh's 2022 Labour Force Survey. 4. TWC2, "Job prematurely ended, Mollah Sharif facing debt collectors in three days," 4 Jul 2017. 5. TWC2, "Injured Azizul given only \$1,000 to live on for 15 months," 30 Oct 2017. 6. TWC2 casework pattern, consistent across multiple published cases including "How filing a salary claim is like going to a casino," 28 Oct 2023 — see [p12](#). 7. M. Platt, G. Baey, B.S.A. Yeoh, C.Y. Khoo, T. Lam, "Debt, precarity and gender: male and female temporary labour migrants in Singapore," *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 43:1 (2017), 119–136. 8. TWC2 institutional commentary, consistent across its 2018 recruitment-cost research and Policy Brief No. 4, "Free up labour mobility."

THE DEBT • THE DIARIST

Sixteen Years, Written Down — and Nearly Ended by a Rumour

Sharif Uddin is the rarest thing this book found on this subject: a Bangladeshi construction worker with his own published, prize-winning, on-the-record voice. In 2024, an anonymous tip almost cost him everything his own writing had already survived.

Sharif Uddin lived and worked in Singapore for sixteen years. In 2019 he published *Stranger to Myself: Diary of a Bangladeshi in Singapore* — Bengali diary entries and poems, written on his phone after shifts between 2008 and 2016, translated into English — which won Best Non-Fiction at the 2018 Singapore Book Awards. A second volume, *Stranger to My World: Covid Diary of a Bangladeshi Migrant Worker*, followed. He appeared at the Singapore Writers Festival in 2017 and 2018 and the Singapore Poetry Festival in 2018.¹ This book quotes no line of either diary without direct attribution, and holds every fact about his 2024 case to the same standard it applies everywhere else.

In March 2024, an anonymous tip falsely accused Uddin of borrowing from an unlicensed moneylender. His employer, Hiap Seng Piling Construction, terminated him on 11 March — reportedly on advice attributed to MOM and the police, which MOM publicly denied giving. A joint MOM-police statement later confirmed a thorough investigation had found no evidence linking him to any unlicensed moneylender.² Cleared, he was not reinstated. A last-minute appeal to extend his stay failed, and he left Singapore on 31 May 2024, after sixteen years, under a public #SharifStays advocacy campaign that could not, in the end, keep him.³

A man can write the definitive diary of his own migration and still not have enough standing, on paper, to argue his own case.

The academic literature has a name for what happens next. Sallie Yea's 2022 study of "failed

migration" among Bangladeshi workers — men who leave still in debt, without recouping the cost of getting there — identifies three registers through which they manage the aftermath: protecting family from the anxiety of the full story, absorbing the suspicion or censure of others who assume something must have gone wrong on his end, and carrying the shame of having been exploited rather than the relief of having escaped it.⁴ None of that requires a scandal. TWC2's 2015–2016 casework alone recorded 1,373 and 1,461 Bangladeshi workers respectively seeking help, the vast majority over injury and salary — routine, not exceptional.⁵

FAST FACTS — SHARIF UDDIN

DETAIL	READING
Years in Singapore	16, to 2024
<i>Stranger to Myself</i>	2018 Book Awards, Best Non-Fiction
2024 termination cause	False moneylender tip
Investigation outcome	Cleared by joint MOM-police probe
Left Singapore	31 May 2024, appeal failed

2

PUBLISHED BOOKS BY SHARIF UDDIN — A BENGALI-LANGUAGE DIARIST'S OWN ON-THE-RECORD VOICE

THE SCEPTIC

This book could not independently verify every detail of Uddin's 2024 termination beyond what Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, Malay Mail and the #SharifStays campaign material report; MOM's side of the record — the joint MOM-police statement clearing him — is treated here with equal weight to the advocacy account, not as a rebuttal to be discounted.

SOURCES 1. South China Morning Post, "From Singapore migrant worker to poet"; Mothership.sg, "Bangladeshi construction worker's diary shares hardships of coming to S'pore, earning S\$18 a day," 2019; Epigram Books, publisher listing for *Stranger to Myself*. 2. Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, three linked 2024 articles on the Hiap Seng Piling Construction case; Malay Mail, "Ministry of Manpower did not advise employer to fire migrant worker harassed by loan sharks, worker can remain in Singapore amid police probe," 6 Apr 2024. 3. Malay Mail, "Migrant worker fired over loan shark harassment leaves Singapore after failing in last-minute appeal," 31 May 2024; wethecitizens.net, "#SharifStays: An urgent update." 4. Sallie Yea, "Transnationalism unstuck: Precarious work and the transnational geographies of failed migration of Bangladeshi migrant workers in Singapore," *Global Networks*, 2022. 5. TWC2, AGM Executive Committee Report, 2017 (covering 2015–2016 caseload).

THE PERMIT · THE REGIME

A Job That Is Legally One Man's, Not One Trade's

Singapore's Work Permit for construction ties a man to a single named employer, not a sector. What that means in practice — and how narrow the door out actually is — is the load-bearing fact of everything else in this book.

A construction Work Permit holder cannot simply change employers. TWC2's long-running "no-consent transfer" scheme — nearly a decade old — lets a worker in construction, marine or process seek a new employer without his current employer's sign-off only inside a narrow window before the permit expires, reported at roughly the last twenty days: TWC2 calls it, without much exaggeration, "the twenty-day obstacle course."¹ The scale of how rarely it actually works: TWC2 reporting puts successful no-consent transfers at somewhere between sixty and a hundred a year, against a construction Work Permit population TWC2 estimates in the hundreds of thousands.² Separately, TWC2 has documented close to eight thousand construction Work Permits cancelled near their expiry date — a pattern consistent with employers timing a termination to close the transfer window rather than open it.³

Before he can work at all, a new arrival must pass the Skills Evaluation Certificate — SEC(K) — administered by Singapore's Building and Construction Authority through BCA-approved testing centres in the source country, a written and practical trade competency test that stands between a man and his first day on site.⁴ One structural change worth flagging as unconfirmed but potentially significant: this book found a single, uncorroborated reference to pre-entry SEC(K) testing being phased out for all source countries — Bangladesh included — from January 2028, with testing moved to Singapore itself within a worker's first year. This book could not verify it against a second source or a primary BCA announcement, and prints it only as a lead for a future edition, not as fact.⁵

The transfer window and the levy are both, on paper, neutral administration. In practice, both hand the employer the only key.

THE RECORD

The Dependency Ratio Ceiling and its associated foreign-worker levy genuinely exist and shape how many migrant workers a construction firm may hire per local employee — but this book's research turned up so many mutually contradictory dollar figures, sourced almost entirely to unverifiable consultancy and immigration-agency websites rather than MOM's own tables, that it declines to print a specific levy rate here rather than risk repeating an invented one. The mechanism is real; the number in your hand should come from mom.gov.sg directly.

THE SCEPTIC

TWC2's characterisation of the transfer and cancellation pattern is consistent and well-cited across years of its own casework, but is TWC2's own framing — this book has not obtained MOM's direct rebuttal to this specific claim, unlike several other TWC2 claims addressed in MOM's public fact-check series (see [p18](#)).

The problem is not new to MOM either. A written parliamentary answer specifically addressed halting work transfers for migrant construction workers as far back as November 2021, and a separate MOM announcement that October billed new measures to "support retention" of Work Permit holders in the construction, marine and process sectors — official acknowledgment that retention inside this workforce is a named policy problem, even where this book could not confirm what concretely changed as a result.⁶

SOURCES 1. TWC2, "The 20-day obstacle course," 8 Sep 2024; "No-consent period for job transfers 'adjusted', in effect shrunk," 29 Nov 2021. 2. TWC2 casework reporting, exact article of origin not independently pinned down this edition. 3. TWC2, "Nearly 8,000 foreign construction workers had permits cancelled close to expiry date," 6 Apr 2021. 4. Building and Construction Authority, "Overseas Trade Testing," bca.gov.sg. 5. Single search-aggregated reference, unconfirmed against a primary BCA/MOM source this edition — see the Sceptic desk, [p20](#). 6. MOM, "Written answer to PQ by Minister on halting work transfers for migrant construction workers," 1 Nov 2021; MOM, "New measures to support retention of WPHs in CMP sectors," 29 Oct 2021.

THE PERMIT • THE WAGE

What the Payslip Says, What the Overtime Log Says

Singapore's Employment Act caps overtime at twelve hours a day and seventy-two hours a month. A 2023 TWC2 survey found most Bangladeshi and Tamil respondents were shorted on it — and most of those did not know.

Under the Employment Act, a low-wage manual worker's day, overtime included, is capped at twelve hours, and his month at seventy-two overtime hours; exceeding either is a criminal offence for the employer.¹ TWC2's 2023 survey of 992 valid responses, predominantly Tamil and Bangladeshi workers in construction, marine and process sectors, found roughly 54% reported being underpaid for overtime worked — and 88% of those underpaid did not realise it, a gap TWC2 attributes to deliberately opaque payslip and allowance structures.² Enforcement is thin and asymmetric: between January 2022 and July 2024, only fourteen companies nationally were convicted or fined for exceeding the overtime limits — thirteen in the security industry, where workers are mostly citizens or permanent residents with a political voice, and just one in construction, where the workforce is almost entirely migrant. In one case TWC2 cites from that same window, a construction worker logged 168 overtime hours in a single month in 2024, more than double the legal cap.³

168 hrs

OVERTIME LOGGED BY ONE CONSTRUCTION WORKER IN A SINGLE MONTH, 2024 — MORE THAN DOUBLE THE LEGAL CAP

1 of 14

OVERTIME-CAP CONVICTIONS, JAN 2022–JUL 2024, THAT CAME FROM THE CONSTRUCTION SECTOR

The clearest current evidence that the courts, at least, are willing to close a loophole employers have used: in [2026] SGHC 73, decided 11 February 2026, Singapore's General Division of the High Court ruled that an employer cannot use a pre-declared "fixed monthly allowance" to offset its legal duty to pay

overtime. The worker, Gena Hulash Ram, fought a two-and-a-half-year case after his employer argued that S\$200 in housing allowance and S\$300 in "other" allowance already covered what it owed him in overtime, calculated at S\$7.87 an hour. The High Court overturned a lower Employment Claims Tribunal ruling and reinstated his claim.⁴ Reported award figures for the case differ between outlets — TWC2 states S\$5,711.11, one wire report states "nearly \$4,500" — and this book has not been able to reconcile the two against the judgment text directly; both figures are printed here, honestly, as unreconciled.⁵

THE RECORD

MOM's own 2024 Migrant Worker Experience and Employer Survey — 2,825 workers interviewed, released August 2025 — found 95.3% self-reported satisfaction, the highest since the survey began in 2011, with "competitive salaries" cited by 71.2% as a factor. HOME publicly disputed the figure's transparency days after release. Both sides of that argument are given their own full accounting on [p20](#).⁶

A separate, well-attested case from 2026 shows the same overtime problem at close range: a worker referred to in TWC2's casework as Awlad logged one hundred overtime hours in September 2025, well past the seventy-two-hour cap, and exceeded the twelve-hour daily limit on at least two occasions that month. A worker in the same TWC2 article is quoted, per the organisation's own reporting, saying simply: "sometimes I cannot feel my body" — this book could not confirm from available material whether that line belongs to Awlad himself or a second worker profiled alongside him, and flags the attribution as unresolved rather than assign it with false confidence.⁷

SOURCES 1. Employment Act (Singapore), overtime provisions, as characterised in TWC2 reporting. 2. TWC2, "Over half of CMP work permit holders underpaid for their overtime work," 17 Nov 2023. 3. TWC2, "Overworked and overlooked: the scourge of excess overtime," 22 Dec 2024. 4. [2026] SGHC 73; TWC2, "High Court rules that fixed allowances cannot 'cover or subsume overtime payments,'" 9 Apr 2026. 5. VnExpress International, case coverage, Apr 2026 — figure conflicts with TWC2's stated award and is not reconciled here. 6. MOM, "Migrant Worker Experience and Employer Survey 2024," released 21 Aug 2025; HOME, "In response to MOM's 'Migrant Worker Experience Survey 2024,'" 1 Sep 2025. 7. TWC2, "Dry numbers on time logs 'cannot feel my body,'" 31 Mar 2026.

THE PERMIT · JUNE 2026

The Case That Was Still Open When This Book Went to Print

On 22 June 2026, more than a hundred migrant workers gathered outside a government office in Bendemeer over two vanished employers. By the time this book was researched, the number had grown to around four hundred.

On 22 June 2026, over a hundred migrant workers gathered at the MOM Services Centre on Bendemeer Road saying they were owed wages by two employers, KPA Engineering and SK Industries, both of whom had become unreachable. Within days the number of workers claiming unpaid wages across both firms rose to roughly four hundred, with reported monthly pay among those affected ranging from about S\$600 to S\$1,300.¹ A KPA Engineering supervisor identified in coverage as "Dinesh" said he was owed almost S\$7,000 in salary unpaid since April; several other employees told reporters they had not been paid in at least two months and could not reach their recruiting agent.² TWC2 said it had already alerted MOM to problems at KPA Engineering before the Bendemeer gathering, having helped six workers file salary claims against the company between 2025 and early 2026.³ The Migrant Workers' Centre — the NTUC- and Singapore National Employers Federation-founded body, not an independent NGO in the TWC2/HOME sense — responded with meals, transport and dormitory outreach and advised workers on filing claims; MOM said it was investigating both companies.⁴

FAST FACTS — THE KPA/SK CASE

DETAIL	READING
First mass gathering	22 Jun 2026, Bendemeer MOM office
Workers affected, by late June	~400, two firms
Reported monthly pay range	S\$600–S\$1,300
TWC2 prior claims filed	6, against KPA alone, 2025–26
Status as researched	MOM investigation open

Set against a single, unresolved case, the structural pattern behind it: sociologist Katie Rainwater's peer-

reviewed study of Singapore's construction workforce, grown out of her own volunteer casework with TWC2, found task assignment on site correlates strongly with nationality — Chinese workers more often placed in skilled trades, Bangladeshi workers disproportionately assigned general labour, and Bangladeshi workers more often hired through manpower-supply agencies rather than directly by the main contractor, unlike their Thai and Chinese counterparts.⁵ Her explanation: Singapore wages are set with reference to conditions in the worker's home economy, and firms read assumed productivity differences into a worker's national and class origin. Separately, TWC2's own survey found Indian and Bangladeshi migrant workers stay an average of 4.2 years with the same employer — long enough, this book's research suggests, for a debt-financed migration to become a career, not a single trip.⁶

4.2 yrs

AVERAGE TENURE WITH ONE EMPLOYER, INDIAN AND BANGLADESHI WORK PERMIT HOLDERS, PER TWC2

Scale matters for reading both facts together: construction alone reportedly accounts for roughly 378,000 Work Permit holders, the single largest such category in the country — yet Bangladeshi hiring has reportedly softened lately, one Bangladeshi-press account describing a firm's ratio of Bangladeshi workers to Singaporean employees falling from seven-to-one to five-to-one amid cooling post-pandemic demand.⁷ No MOM table breaks that 378,000 down by nationality, so this book cannot state a precise Bangladeshi share — only that the workforce is large enough for a single wage-theft case to draw four hundred men to one office in a week.

SOURCES 1. Human Resources Online, "At least 100 migrant workers in Singapore report unpaid wages at two firms; MWC responds"; The Online Citizen, "Migrant workers claiming unpaid wages from KPA Engineering and SK Industries rise to about 400," 24 Jun 2026. 2. Attributed via secondary coverage to The Straits Times, Jun 2026 — direct article not independently opened this edition. 3. The Online Citizen, "MOM alerted to KPA Engineering wage issues prior to early 2026 before workers gathered at MOM office: TWC2," 25 Jun 2026. 4. NTUC/Migrant Workers' Centre, statement on KPA Engineering and SK Industries response, Jun 2026. 5. Katie Rainwater, "Building Inequality: Wage Disparity between Bangladeshi and Thai Guestworkers in Singapore's Construction Industry," *Work, Employment and Society*, 2021. 6. TWC2, "On average, Indian and Bangladeshi migrant workers stay 4.2 years with the same employer, our survey finds," 18 Oct 2021. 7. MOM foreign-workforce numbers, via data.gov.sg dataset reference (not independently confirmed against the primary table this edition); The Business Standard (Bangladesh), "Why Singapore job market shrinking for Bangladeshis."

THE DORMITORY • BEFORE

The Room That Made Distancing a Joke

Before 2020, TWC2 was already calling dormitory density "nearly ideal for transmission of infection." The pandemic did not create the condition. It exposed one that had been priced into the system for years.

In April 2020, weeks into the pandemic, TWC2 described dormitory rooms typically packing twelve to twenty men into roughly ninety square metres, ten double-decker beds spaced about a metre apart — a density the organisation called "nearly ideal for transmission of infection," where social distancing would be "laughable" to implement.¹ Academic field research from a few years earlier corroborates the shape of the claim: Sallie Yea, who spent eighteen months from 2014–15 interviewing close to two hundred Indian and Bangladeshi construction workmen, described conditions as "cramped rooms housing up to thirty men apiece, no air-conditioning or appropriate ventilation, bed bugs and cockroaches, and often just one filthy toilet shared by more than eighty people."²

The outbreak, when it came, moved fast and became the defining story of Singapore's pandemic. S11 Dormitory @ Punggol — a facility that had won a "Dormitory Award" in 2018 — and Westlite Toh Guan were gazetted as Singapore's first two isolation-area dormitories on 5 April 2020, placing close to 20,000 workers under quarantine between the two sites. S11@Punggol's own case count ran from 22 new cases that day to 98 by 7 April, 586 by 14 April, and past 2,100 by late April — briefly Singapore's single largest cluster.³ By 6 May 2020, dormitory residents accounted for roughly 88% of Singapore's then-national COVID-19 case total; by December 2020, one estimate put cumulative dormitory prevalence at 47% of an estimated 295,000 low-wage migrant residents, combining PCR- and serology-confirmed cases.⁴

2,143

CONFIRMED CASES AT S11@PUNGGOL ALONE BY LATE APRIL 2020, SINGAPORE'S LARGEST SINGLE CLUSTER

88%

SHARE OF SINGAPORE'S NATIONAL COVID-19 CASE TOTAL FROM DORMITORIES, AS OF 6 MAY 2020

THE RECORD

The Bangladesh High Commission in Singapore estimated roughly 130,000 Bangladeshi migrants were working in the country at the time, most in crowded dormitories. Bangladeshi-press reporting put Bangladeshi nationals at about 8,000 of Singapore's 18,788 confirmed cases in April 2020, including one reported fatality.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

A separately reported claim — that roughly 40% of Singapore's total infected were Bangladeshi nationals — surfaced only as an unattributed paraphrase in this book's research and is not printed as a stated fact; the 8,000-of-18,788 figure above, tied to a specific date and a named Bangladeshi outlet, is the more defensible number.

The regulatory backdrop that let density like this stand for years: the Foreign Employee Dormitories Act 2015, in force from 1 January 2016, required licensing only for dormitories housing more than 1,000 beds — smaller factory-converted dormitories, exactly the category later found sleeping 26 men to a room (p11), sat outside that licensing net entirely.⁶ By late April 2020, the outbreak had outgrown its first two sites badly enough that five more dormitories were gazetted as isolation areas on the 20th, then four more on the 24th, bringing the total to 25 — and the crisis did not fully clear until 25 November 2020, when Singapore recorded its first day with zero active COVID-19 clusters since 3 February that year.⁷

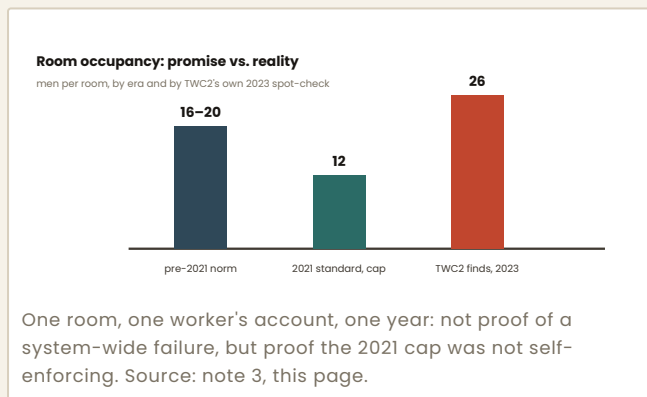
SOURCES 1. TWC2, statement reported in The Online Citizen, "TWC2: Condition of the migrant worker's dormitories nearly ideal for transmission of infection," 7 Apr 2020. 2. Sallie Yea, "This is why Singapore's coronavirus cases are growing," *The Conversation*, 2020. 3. Mothership.sg, dormitory-cluster case-count reporting, Apr 2020; The Online Citizen, S11 award/revenue reporting (revenue figure single-sourced, not printed here). 4. IHRB, "Accommodating the Spread — Migrant Worker Accommodation Driving COVID"; CGTN, "Half of Singapore's migrant workers in dormitories have had COVID-19," 16 Dec 2020. 5. The Business Standard (Bangladesh), "Bangladeshi workers at the centre of Singapore's Covid-19 resurgence," 21 May 2020. 6. Singapore Statutes Online, Foreign Employee Dormitories Act 2015. 7. The Online Citizen, dormitory isolation-area gazette reporting, 20 & 24 Apr 2020; Malay Mail, "Singapore reports no active Covid-19 clusters for first time since Feb 3," 25 Nov 2020.

THE DORMITORY · AFTER

Twenty-Six Men, One Room, Two Years After the Standard Said Twelve

Singapore announced new dormitory standards in 2021. This book checked what actually happened by 2023, 2024 and 2026 — and found the honest answer sits between reform and rebrand.

MOM announced New Dormitory Standards in September 2021 and, from 2023, an interim Dormitory Transition Scheme covering roughly a thousand existing dormitories — a 12-person room cap and ensuite toilets by 2030 on the way to a fuller 4.2 square-metre-per-resident standard by 2040.¹ TWC2's own framing of the 2021 announcement at the time: standards "packaged as new dorm standards" that were, in substance, disease-control measures.² The clearest test of the gap between announcement and reality: in August 2023, a worker TWC2 identifies as Islam Din, in a factory-converted dormitory in Sungei Kadut, told the organisation: "In my dormitory, one room sleeping 26 man." At six such rooms per floor, TWC2 calculated roughly 130 men to a floor — exceeding not only the new 12-person standard but the older, pre-reform informal norm of sixteen to twenty.³



The exemption pattern is the more systemic finding. In January 2024, TWC2 said it was "disheartened" that roughly 40% of existing dormitories were exempted from even the interim Dormitory

Transition Scheme standard.⁴ By 2026, TWC2's own institutional emphasis had shifted: an April 2026 article titled "Dormitories are a secondary issue" argued that debt bondage, wage theft and deceptive recruitment — the subjects of the two chapters before this one — now matter more to the organisation than physical dormitory conditions.⁵ That is not this book's assessment alone; it is the position of the NGO that has spent two decades documenting dormitory conditions specifically, effectively downgrading its own signature issue. Many dormitories, per a 2025 TWC2 note, still lack cooking facilities, leaving workers dependent on catered meals delivered hours before they're eaten.⁶

Institutionally, MOM's own response to the 2020 crisis moved fast on paper: a new Assurance, Care and Engagement Group stood up in August 2020 to take over migrant-worker support from the pandemic-era Inter-Agency Taskforce, and by that same month a network of thirteen regional and on-site medical centres plus a telemedicine app were serving dormitory residents directly.⁷ MOM has also engaged TWC2's specific claims head-on rather than staying silent — a 2024 fact-check responds directly to a TWC2 article alleging mistreatment and confinement of migrant workers, disputing its characterisation of events, a dispute this book treats as live and unresolved on the public record rather than settled by either side's account alone.⁸

4.2 sqm

PER-RESIDENT SPACE TARGET UNDER THE FULL NEW DORMITORY STANDARDS, PHASED IN BY 2040

SOURCES 1. MOM, "Improved standards for new migrant worker dormitories," 17 Sep 2021; Dormitory Transition Scheme reporting via Human Resources Director (Asia) and The Independent (Singapore). 2. TWC2, "Government announces new standards for control of virus, packaged as new dorm standards," 30 Sep 2021. 3. TWC2, "One room sleeping 26 man," 27 Aug 2023. 4. Gutzy Asia, "TWC2 disheartened by exemption of 40% PBDs from DTS interim standards," 25 Jan 2024. 5. TWC2, "Dormitories are a secondary issue," says TWC2," 13 Apr 2026. 6. TWC2, "Good diet and good health remain challenges," 4 Mar 2025. 7. MOM, "New MOM division to support migrant workers and dormitory operations," 22 Aug 2020; PSD Challenge, "Caring For Migrant Workers In The Time Of The Pandemic." 8. MOM, "Response to TWC2 article on alleged mistreatment of and confinement of MW," 2024.

THE LEDGER • THE MACHINERY

No-Fault, in Theory. Employer-Tied, in Practice.

Singapore's injury and wage-dispute systems are built to be neutral. This book found the neutrality is real on paper and consistently undercut by the one fact that overrides it: a Work Permit is only as safe as the relationship it depends on.

The Work Injury Compensation Act (WICA) is genuinely no-fault: a worker can claim for an on-the-job injury without proving negligence and without a lawyer, and compensation limits rose roughly 19% from 1 November 2025 — the death-benefit floor moving from S\$76,000 to S\$91,000, the ceiling from S\$261,000 to S\$269,000.¹ Salary disputes run through the Tripartite Alliance for Dispute Management (TADM), which mediates rather than adjudicates: more than 80% of claims are reported resolved at mediation, most within two months, and foreign employees filed 5,916 of TADM's 11,685 total 2024 claims — 60.1% of the total.²

TWC2's sharpest structural critique concerns what TADM counts as success. Its October 2025 analysis of TADM's own 2024 report argues the tribunal's "full recovery" metric can describe a straightforward compromise: TWC2 cites an illustrative case in which a worker calculated he was owed \$12,500, his employer pleaded insufficient funds, the two sides settled at \$6,000, and TADM's own reporting logged the \$6,000 outcome as a full recovery — a label TWC2 argues is possible only because TADM does not rule on who was actually owed what.³ The deeper mechanism, documented across years of TWC2 casework: the worker Alom filed a salary claim for \$600, his employer conceded to pay it in full before mediation even began — and he was repatriated to Bangladesh the very next day.⁴

Winning a claim and keeping your job in Singapore turn out to be two separate questions. TADM answers the first. Nobody answers the second.

THE RECORD

MOM runs a public "fact-checks" series rebutting specific TWC2 case articles point by point — a genuine, ongoing evidentiary back-and-forth between regulator and NGO, not silence on either side. This book gives both a fair hearing on [p18–19](#) rather than adjudicating it here.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

TWC2's own casework confirms the system does sometimes work as designed: in one October 2025 case, MOM investigated a worker's complaint and granted Change-of-Employer letters to all six workers implicated, letting them seek new jobs while claims were pending. This book does not treat the machinery as uniformly broken — only as unevenly enforced.

TADM itself is not a MOM enforcement arm but a body jointly set up in 2017 by MOM, NTUC and the Singapore National Employers Federation. A separate 2025 TWC2 case shows how much discretion sits inside the mediation model even when it works: a worker's salary claim settled in full, but TADM declined her request for the Change-of-Employer letter that would let her seek new local work — a decision TWC2 argues contradicts stated policy that such letters should follow automatically from a valid claim, "not conditional on employer's pleasure."⁶

60.1%

SHARE OF TADM'S 2024 EMPLOYMENT CLAIMS FILED BY
FOREIGN EMPLOYEES

SOURCES 1. MOM, "Higher compensation limits under the Work Injury Compensation Act," 2 Aug 2024, effective 1 Nov 2025. 2. Tripartite Alliance for Dispute Management, 2024 report, as analysed by TWC2, "Woolly 'fully' — TADM's 2024 report," 20 Oct 2025. 3. Same source. 4. TWC2, "Short of foreign labour, Singapore sending workers home even when they want to stay and work," 23 May 2021. 5. MOM Newsroom Fact-Checks index, mom.gov.sg — page titles confirmed, full text not independently opened this edition. 6. NTUC, "Launch of Tripartite Alliance for Dispute Management," 2017; TWC2, "When TADM's discretion becomes the employer's bargaining chip," 25 Jul 2025.

THE LEDGER • THE COUNT

Forty-Three Deaths, No Nationality Column

Singapore publishes exact, sector-by-sector workplace fatality figures every year. It does not publish how many of the dead were Bangladeshi — a gap this book treats as a finding in its own right, not an oversight to smooth over.

MOM's Workplace Safety and Health National Statistics recorded 43 workplace deaths in 2024, up from 36 in 2023; construction was the single largest contributor at 20, ahead of transportation and storage (9) and marine (5) — together, three sectors accounted for 80% of all fatalities.¹ This book's research searched specifically for a nationality breakdown within MOM's published statistics and found none: the reports are organised by industry, not by the worker's country of origin. That silence is worth stating plainly rather than working around — there is no public official figure for how many Bangladeshi construction workers have died on Singapore worksites in any given year.²

43

SINGAPORE WORKPLACE DEATHS, 2024, UP FROM 36 IN 2023

20 of 43

2024 WORKPLACE DEATHS RECORDED IN CONSTRUCTION — THE SINGLE LARGEST SECTOR

Named cases this book could verify, reported individually rather than folded into a statistic: a 31-year-old Bangladeshi rigger employed by Nardev Builders died 25 January 2025 at a Raffles Place site when the ground gave way beneath him during lifting works and he fell three metres into a piling pit.³ A Bangladeshi worker at a Seatrium warehouse in Tuas South died 26 February 2025, struck on the head by a steel beam while repairing a cargo lift — reported at the time as the third fatal workplace accident of 2025.⁴ Sanjay Kumar Biswas, reported by The Daily Star (Bangladesh) as a Bangladeshi migrant worker, was struck in the neck by a forklift on 16 April 2024 at a Sungei Kadut site and died six days later; the

employing company said it was arranging insurance-based compensation for his family.⁵

FAST FACTS — WSH NATIONAL STATISTICS

MEASURE	2023	2024
Workplace deaths, total	36	43
Construction-sector deaths	—	20
Top-3 sectors' share of deaths	—	80%

On the advocacy side, HOME logged 1,649 salary-related complaints at its helpdesk in 2023 alone — unpaid or delayed pay, missing overtime, unauthorised deductions, pay that did not match what was promised.⁶ TWC2's Cuff Road Project, a food programme specifically for South Asian workers barred from paid work while a MOM claim is pending, served roughly 45,500 meals to 1,088 workers in 2025 — support that exists, TWC2's own casework notes stress, not as charity for its own sake but to keep a man solvent long enough to see a claim through.⁷

The 2025 WSH statistics, published as this book went to research, show construction still leading combined fatal-and-major injuries — 148 incidents, 24% of the national total — though the sector's own injury rate fell from 31.0 per 100,000 workers in 2024 to 26.3 in 2025, alongside a national major-injury rate at its lowest recorded level.⁸ One reporting-threshold change matters for reading any of these trend lines honestly: since amendments effective September 2020, employers must report every work injury involving any medical leave or light duty, not only the more serious 4-day-MC-or-more threshold used before January 2021 — meaning pre- and post-2021 injury figures are not directly comparable, a caveat this book states because MOM's own published tables do not always foreground it.⁹

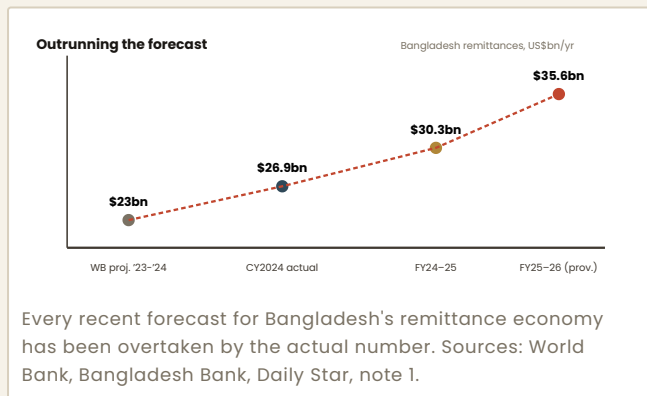
SOURCES 1. MOM, Workplace Safety and Health National Statistics 2024, published 26 Mar 2025. 2. This book's own search of MOM's published WSH tables; absence noted, not confirmed exhaustive against every underlying dataset. 3. The Online Citizen; STOMP; Mothership, coverage of the Raffles Place site fatality, 28–29 Jan 2025 — worker's name not located in available coverage. 4. Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, "Singapore: Bangladeshi worker killed in accident at Seatrium warehouse," 2025. 5. The Daily Star (Bangladesh), "Bangladeshi migrant worker dies after forklift incident in Singapore"; Mustsharenews, corroborating report. 6. HOME, "Salary Claims: Victory's Shadow, Defeat's Echo," 24 Jul 2024. 7. TWC2, The Cuff Road Project, 2025 service figures. 8. MOM, Workplace Safety and Health National Statistics 2025. 9. MOM/ask.gov.sg, "What are major injuries and minor injuries?"; WICA reporting-threshold amendment, effective Sep 2020.

THE REMITTANCE • THE MONEY

Thirty-Five Billion Dollars, and a World Bank Forecast It Blew Past

Bangladesh's remittance economy broke its own record again this year. Singapore is a real but middling piece of it – and a wide, honestly-reported band of that money still moves through a channel the state calls illegal.

Bangladesh received a provisional \$35.56 billion in workers' remittances in FY2025–26, up 17.3% on FY2024–25's \$30.32–30.33 billion, itself up sharply from \$26.88 billion in calendar 2024 – a run of records that has overtaken every forecast made along the way. As recently as 2023, the World Bank projected Bangladesh's remittances would stay roughly flat near \$23 billion through 2024.¹ Bangladesh Bank data reported via Prothom Alo shows 62% of that inflow arrives from just five countries – Saudi Arabia, the United Kingdom, the UAE, Malaysia and the United States – putting Singapore outside the top tier. The clearest figure this book could confirm for Singapore's own share: 5.17% of remittance earnings in the January–March quarter of FY2025, per Bangladesh Bank's own quarterly report.² An exact current national ranking for Singapore beyond that quarter's share could not be confirmed and is not printed as if it were known.



5.17%

SINGAPORE'S SHARE OF BANGLADESH BANK-REPORTED REMITTANCE EARNINGS, Q1 FY2025

6th / 8th

BANGLADESH'S GLOBAL RANK AS A MIGRANT-SENDING COUNTRY / REMITTANCE-RECEIVING COUNTRY, PER IOM

The scale behind that ranking is worth stating plainly: Bangladeshi workers have taken nearly 16.1 million short-term overseas labour contracts across 164 countries since 1976, the overwhelming majority in the Gulf, and more than 7.4 million Bangladesh-born people lived abroad as of a 2020 UN estimate.³ Roughly half a million people leave Bangladesh for work every year in recent years – though a Bangladeshi digital migration-tracking platform recorded a 27.4% year-on-year decline in overseas migration in 2024, attributed to structural and political reforms following that year's political transition, before numbers reportedly recovered by October.⁴ Singapore's construction sector sits inside that much larger current, not apart from it: this is a national migration system built at Gulf-corridor scale, of which the Singapore route this book has spent thirteen pages on is one significant but comparatively modest lane.

THE SCEPTIC

Older Singapore-specific dollar figures circulating in secondary sources – \$457.4m in FY2019–20, \$368.3m in FY2018–19 – trace to aggregator sites rather than a Bangladesh Bank table this book opened directly, and are not printed here as confirmed.

SOURCES 1. BSS News, Financial Express (Bangladesh) and Asia News Network, FY2025–26 provisional remittance total; The Daily Star, "Remittances hit record \$32b in 2025"; World Bank flat-remittance projection, as reported by The Business Standard and The Daily Star, 2023. 2. Prothom Alo (English), "Bangladesh Bank data: 62pc of remittances from just 5 countries"; Bangladesh Bank, Quarterly Report on Remittance Inflows, Jan–Mar FY25. 3. Migration Policy Institute, "Bangladesh's Economic Vitality Owes in Part to Migration and Remittances." 4. EUAA (European Union Agency for Asylum), "Bangladesh: Country Focus," Aug 2025 – originating digital-platform name not identified this edition.

THE REMITTANCE • THE VILLAGE

Brick Houses on Old Paddy Fields, and What They Cost the Men Who Built Them

Roughly half of Bangladesh's remittance economy still moves outside the banking system entirely. The half that arrives formally is visibly rebuilding entire villages — and, per the country's own researchers, quietly reshaping the households the money is sent to support.

Bangladesh's finance minister has put the informal share — hundi, an unwritten trust-based transfer network bypassing the formal banking system entirely — at roughly 49% of total remittances, a share reporting suggests was near this level even before the pandemic; a wider academic range puts it anywhere from 22% to 56%.¹ The reason is arithmetic, not culture: reported bank remittance rates run around Tk 109.5 to the dollar against an informal-market rate of Tk 117–119, a gap of at least six taka that a World Bank-cited elasticity finding says shifts 3.6% of remittances from formal to informal channels for every one-percentage-point the rates diverge.² The cost of using the formal system honestly, at least in 2024, was itself steep: Bangladeshi migrant workers reportedly lost a combined \$1.3 billion that year to transfer fees and unfavourable exchange margins — an average of \$9.40 per \$100 sent, nearly triple the rate three years earlier.³

What the money that does arrive formally actually builds is visible at village scale. South Mahini, a village of about 6,000 people in Cumilla's Nangalkot upazila, has at least 500 residents working abroad, mostly in the Gulf; remittance money has rebuilt roads once lined by ponds and paddy fields into brick houses and the occasional duplex, a transformation reporting describes as reaching every union across the sub-district.⁴ Cumilla itself ranks third nationally in remittance inflows behind Dhaka and Chattogram, per BMET.⁵ A comparable, UK-linked pattern — included here for contrast, not as a Singapore fact — is Sylhet's "Londoni" phenomenon: over 95% of British Bangladeshis trace their origin there, and the district is reported, in one still-unconfirmed index, to rank among the poorest in the country despite being its third-largest remittance recipient, its money going more into visible housing than education or health.⁶

FAST FACTS — THE HUNDI GAP

CHANNEL	REPORTED SHARE
Formal, banked remittance	~49%–78%
Hundi, informal network	~22%–51%
2024 losses to fees/FX margin	\$1.3bn

A house with two storeys and a satellite dish is not proof a family is doing well. It is proof a father has been away long enough to pay for one.

The social cost is real, documented and specifically under-attended. RMMRU's 2020 study "Social Cost of Migration" — the most direct academic source on this theme this book located, though not read in full this edition — reports left-behind wives gaining greater decision-making authority over household finances in some households, alongside the harder-edged finding that migrants who return before their contract ends, for any reason, commonly face debt, little savings and social stigma on top of it; the stigma is reported as falling hardest on female returnees specifically.⁷ One Bangladeshi commentary piece put the emotional trade plainly, in a sentence this book flags as opinion prose rather than a spoken quotation: "a polished two-storey house built with Gulf earnings may conceal a decade of loneliness, anxiety, and unarticulated grief."⁸

THE SCEPTIC

Almost everything vivid this book found on remittance-driven village transformation and probashi social cost concerns Gulf-corridor migration, not Singapore specifically. No on-the-record quote from a Bangladeshi construction worker in Singapore, about his own remittances or his own absence, surfaced in this book's research — a real gap this book states rather than papers over.

SOURCES 1. The Business Standard, "How Bangladesh can fulfil its \$40b remittance potential"; New Age (Bangladesh), "Breaking hundi cycle." 2. The Daily Star, "Why remitters still prefer hundi." 3. The Business Standard, "How Bangladeshi workers lost \$1.3b in remittance fees, exchange rate volatility in 2024." 4. The Business Standard, "How expats' money reshaping lives in villages." 5. Same source, citing BMET district-ranking data. 6. The Daily Star, "Remittance-rich Sylhet ranks poorest in new index" — underlying index name/methodology unconfirmed this edition. 7. Tasneem Siddiqui and Anas Ansar, "Social Cost of Migration," RMMRU, 2020. 8. The Financial Express (Bangladesh), "Unpacking emotional costs of remittance narrative" — analytical/opinion prose, not an interview quotation.

THE RIOT · THE NIGHT

Singapore's Worst Public Disorder in Forty Years

This chapter is not about Bangladeshi workers specifically — the riot's own record names an Indian national as the man who died, and Indian nationals as the overwhelming majority of those deported for it. It belongs in this book anyway, because its policy shadow still falls across every South Asian migrant worker in Singapore, Bangladeshi men included.

On 8 December 2013, a private bus ferrying migrant workers from Little India to their dormitory fatally struck Sakthivel Kumaravelu, a 33-year-old Indian national construction worker, near the junction of Race Course Road. What followed — variously reported as involving three hundred to an estimated four hundred and twenty rioters, over roughly two hours — became Singapore's worst outbreak of public disorder in about forty years: 25 emergency vehicles damaged, five set alight, injury counts reported inconsistently between eighteen and forty-three depending on outlet and hour.¹ This book states that inconsistency plainly rather than choosing a number to sound precise. What is clearly documented: 52 Indian nationals and one Bangladeshi national were deported for their role in the attack on emergency crews and vehicles — of the men actually punished, all but one were Indian, not Bangladeshi.²

A four-member Committee of Inquiry, chaired by former Supreme Court judge G. Pannir Selvam, held 24 days of public hearings from 19 February to 26 March 2014 and interviewed more than three hundred witnesses. Its central finding: the fatal accident was the riot's primary, triggering cause, compounded by an alcohol-fuelled crowd and a crowd misperception that police were protecting the driver rather than attending to the victim.³ A finding this book considers load-bearing for its own framing: the Committee said it did not believe the riot reflected worker dissatisfaction with employment or living conditions, reporting that "every foreign

worker who the Committee spoke to testified emphatically that they were happy with their jobs and living quarters in Singapore and condemned the riot" — language this book treats as a close paraphrase of the report rather than a confirmed verbatim quotation.⁴

52 & 1

INDIAN AND BANGLADESHI NATIONALS RESPECTIVELY
DEPORTED FOR THE RIOT — THE CLEAREST DOCUMENTED
NATIONALITY SPLIT

THE RECORD

The Committee's report made eight recommendations, including improved police communications and command capability, more frontline training for large public-order incidents, and — notably — more amenities and infrastructure for foreign workers at congregation areas like Little India, not fewer.⁵

The immediate government response, in the days before the Committee even convened: dormitory bus services into Little India were frozen entirely as a cooling-off measure on 13 December, five days after the riot, and the Committee itself was appointed the same week by then-Deputy Prime Minister and Home Affairs Minister Teo Chee Hean.⁶ On the driver whose bus struck Kumaravelu: Singapore's Attorney-General's Chambers determined in February 2014 that no offence had been committed and no further action would be taken against him — a finding this book states because it closes a question a reader might otherwise be left holding.⁷

SOURCES 1. Malay Mail, multi-part December 2013–February 2014 coverage; Southeast Asia Globe, "Remembering Singapore's Little India Riots"; IBTimes UK and Philippine Daily Inquirer/AFP, contemporaneous injury-count reporting (figures unreconciled). 2. CNN, "Singapore to deport foreign workers over 'Little India' riot," 18 Dec 2013; Deccan Herald, "Singapore riot: 52 Indians deported." 3. Mothership.sg, Committee of Inquiry summary; Malay Mail, "Little India riot was sparked off by accident, inquiry panel says," 1 Jul 2014. 4. Committee of Inquiry report findings, as characterised in secondary reporting — not independently confirmed against the primary report text this edition. 5. TWC2, "Committee of Inquiry issues report on Little India riot," 3 Jul 2014 — partial recommendation list, not all eight independently confirmed. 6. Malay Mail, "Singapore freezes Little India bus service ban in cooling-off move," 13 Dec 2013; Mothership.sg, Committee of Inquiry appointment summary. 7. Malay Mail, "Little India riot: No action to be taken against bus driver," 12 Feb 2014.

THE RIOT • THE SHADOW

The Alcohol Law, the Bus Curfew, and the Mega-Dormitory Strategy

Singapore's response to one night in 2013 still governs how every South Asian migrant worker spends a Sunday off, more than a decade later — including men who were not born yet, or not yet in the country, when it happened.

Parliament passed the Public Order (Additional Temporary Measures) Act within six weeks of the riot, giving police powers to ban individuals from Little India for up to 30 days and fast-track licence suspensions; retail alcohol sales were banned in the area from 8pm to 6am on weekends and public holidays, with public consumption an offence carrying a first-time fine up to S\$1,000.¹ The Liquor Control (Supply and Consumption) Act, passed in 2015, made the alcohol restrictions permanent, designating Little India and other areas as fixed Liquor Control Zones.² Dormitory-bound buses out of Little India are now required to leave by 9pm — a rule that measurably shortens the one evening a week many migrant workers get in the city. And in August 2014, the first of a planned nine "mega-dormitories" opened in Tuas, a 16,800-bed facility with its own mini-mart, beer garden and cinema, built explicitly to reduce the need to travel into Little India for recreation at all.³

Singapore's answer to a riot involving mostly Indian nationals was to make Little India itself smaller for every migrant worker in the country — Bangladeshi men included, whether or not any of them were there that night.

Little India's own migrant-facing businesses absorbed the cost: reporting five years on from the

riot described revenue falling by as much as 50% for shops catering to migrant workers, attributed directly to the new restrictions.⁴ Academic literature has since read the episode as a template, not an isolated event. Joe Greener's 2022 analysis argues Singapore built a "mass architecture of alcohol-related governing through crime" out of morally charged discourse about South Asian migrant drinking, placing workers' lives under what he calls "permanent and constant surveillance." Legal scholar Jaclyn Neo's 2015 study argues the regulatory framework around migrant labour more broadly conceptualises this workforce as structurally unsuited for inclusion in wider Singaporean society — a claim this book treats as a serious academic argument, not an established fact, and prints attributed as such.⁵

FAST FACTS — THE POLICY SHADOW

MEASURE	READING
Public Order Act passed	Within 6 weeks of the riot
Alcohol restrictions	Made permanent, 2015
Dormitory-bound bus curfew	Must leave by 9pm
Migrant-facing business revenue	Down ~50%, 5-yr follow-up

THE SCEPTIC

This book could not confirm, in the time available, whether the 2013 riot is directly invoked in the policy discourse around the 2020 dormitory COVID crisis ([p10](#)) — a plausible connective thread this book leaves open rather than asserts.

SOURCES 1. Malay Mail, "Bill seeks to give police extra powers in Little India area," 21 Jan 2014; Business Standard, "New law to keep order in Little India comes to effect in Singapore," 1 Apr 2014. 2. Liquor Control (Supply and Consumption) Act 2015 — title/date via secondary reference, not independently opened this edition. 3. Mothership.sg, "This is how the Little India riot in 2013 has changed the area for better or worse," 2017; Southeast Asia Globe, mega-dormitory strategy reporting. 4. The Independent (Singapore), "5 Years after Little India Riot, Streets are Safer but Businesses Still Experiencing a Slump." 5. Joe Greener, "Moralising racial regimes: surveillance and control after Singapore's 'Little India riots,'" 2022; Jaclyn L. Neo, "Riots and Rights: Law and Exclusion in Singapore's Migrant Worker Regime," *Asian Journal of Law and Society* 2:1 (2015), 137–168.

THE ARGUMENT • THE ADVOCATES

Who Actually Speaks for a Migrant Worker in Singapore

Four organisations get called "migrant worker advocates" in Singapore press. This book found they are not the same kind of organisation at all – and that distinction changes how much weight each one's claims should carry.

TWC2 (Transient Workers Count Too), founded 2004, and HOME (Humanitarian Organization for Migration Economics), also founded 2004, are Singapore's two independent, sustained-advocacy migrant-worker NGOs – both run casework, both publish research, and both have jointly submitted reports on migrant-worker conditions, including a January 2026 joint submission to the UN's Universal Periodic Review of Singapore arguing that policy changes since the 2021 review cycle have not addressed "deeper structural inequalities."¹ TWC2's core policy ask is closer to zero-fee recruitment: it argues migrant workers "should not have to bear the cost of their recruitment, any more than highly paid professionals do," and has specifically proposed barring Singapore employers from hiring through private, for-profit middlemen in high-fee source countries, in favour of licensed non-profit channels.²

The Migrant Workers' Centre (MWC) is a different kind of body entirely, and this book corrects a common conflation here: MWC was founded in 2009 by NTUC (the labour movement) and the Singapore National Employers Federation – unions and employers, not an independent watchdog – and it operates a satellite desk inside MOM's own Work Pass processing hall and runs government-appointed Migrant Worker Recreation Centres on NTUC's behalf.³ ItsRainingRaincoats, founded 2015 by lawyer Dipa Swaminathan, is narrower still: a welfare and goodwill charity running excursions, English classes and health outreach, with no evidence in this book's research of it issuing formal policy proposals or campaigning on recruitment-fee or wage reform – a distinction some sympathetic press coverage blurs by calling its work "advocacy" regardless.⁴

2

INDEPENDENT, POLICY-CAMPAIGNING MIGRANT-WORKER NGOS IN SINGAPORE – TWC2 AND HOME – VERSUS TWO WELFARE/SERVICE BODIES OFTEN DESCRIBED THE SAME WAY

THE RECORD

An independent academic source not affiliated with any of these organisations makes the same structural distinction: a 2024 Asian Labour Review analysis contrasts HOME and TWC2's "older, more confrontational, independent-advocacy tradition" against newer migrant-worker groups that "did not engage in confrontational advocacy towards the state and tended to work within prescribed political boundaries" – a framing this book adopts because it is corroborated, not invented, though it does not confirm the article names MWC specifically by name.⁵

TWC2's specific reform proposals go beyond the zero-fee principle itself: it has argued for a centralised MOM jobs portal listing every Work Permit vacancy, to cut informal middlemen out of the matching process entirely, and documents how workers commonly finance a fee by selling land and family jewellery and taking high-interest loans that, combined with low wages, can trap a man in years of repayment before he sees any income of his own.⁶ HOME runs on a comparable structure – welfare, empowerment and advocacy as its three stated pillars – operating helpdesks serving a reported 2,000 workers a year and a shelter housing roughly 700 people annually, most of them women.⁷ MWC, for its part, describes its own mission around four pillars – fairness, assistance, integration and representation – run through walk-in centres, mobile dormitory and worksite visits, and a seat inside MOM's own processing hall: real, useful infrastructure, organised on a fundamentally different premise from TWC2 and HOME's independent-watchdog model.⁸

SOURCES 1. TWC2, "Universal Periodic Review 2026: TWC2 and HOME submit joint report," 6 Jan 2026. 2. TWC2, "END INJUSTICE IN MIGRANT WORKERS' RECRUITMENT FEES," policy report, Jan 2021. 3. Migrant Workers' Centre, "About Us," mwc.org.sg; NTUC, related-organisations listing. 4. ItsRainingRaincoats, "Who We Are"; Tatler Asia, "ItsRainingRaincoats turns 10." 5. Asian Labour Review, "Migrant Labour Politics in Singapore: the Emergence of New Social Forces," Nov 2024. 6. TWC2, "Recruitment reform" campaign page, twc2.org.sg. 7. HOME, "What We Do," home.org.sg – caseload figures via search-aggregated reference, not independently confirmed against a primary HOME page this edition. 8. Migrant Workers' Centre, "About Us," mwc.org.sg.

THE ARGUMENT • THE MINISTRY

MOM's Own Case, Given Its Full Weight

A ministry's defence of its own pace of reform is not automatically the weaker argument in a room. This book puts MOM's stated reasoning next to the NGOs' critique, in its own words, and lets both stand.

MOM's central jurisdictional position, restated across parliamentary answers: recruitment fees are typically charged in a worker's country of origin, outside Singapore's legal reach, so its regulatory power runs only to what happens inside Singapore itself — the Employment Agencies Act, amended in 2011, caps what a Singapore-licensed agency may charge at two months' salary per two-year permit, a cap MOM cannot extend to an agent operating in Dhaka.¹ In a September 2025 parliamentary reply, MOM disclosed that first-time non-domestic Work Permit holders in construction paid a reported \$1,000 to \$7,800 in 2024 — but declined to break the figure down by nationality, citing "sensitivities bilaterally and among different communities in Singapore."² MOM also runs an active, public fact-check series directly rebutting specific TWC2 case reports — in one 2024 exchange over a worker MOM's response calls "Rafiqu," MOM states it arranged alternative housing by the next day after TWC2 had characterised the same case as a near-homelessness failure. This book treats that specific dispute as a genuine, unresolved disagreement about the same facts, not as a rebuttal that settles the matter either way.³

**THE TWC2 /
ADVOCACY HOME
FRAME**

Fees, wages and enforcement are set up in ways that structurally favour the employer; a ministry fact-check that wins one case-by-case argument does not answer the pattern across thousands of workers who never file at all.

**THE MINISTRY MOM
FRAME**

Singapore's legal jurisdiction genuinely stops at its own border; within that border, enforcement is real, documented and improving, and a single NGO case study is not a representative sample of a workforce numbering in the hundreds of thousands.

Both sides are arguing from real evidence. The disagreement is not about whether problems exist — it is about how much of the fix is actually in Singapore's hands.

THE SCEPTIC

MOM cited Indonesia and the Philippines moving to zero-placement-fee models on the source-country side as far back as 2020–2021 — an implicit acknowledgment, this book reads it, that origin-side reform is where the real leverage sits, which is precisely TWC2 and HOME's argument too. The two "sides" agree more on the diagnosis than the framing suggests.

MOM's fact-check series is not a one-off gesture — the newsroom index shows entries responding to TWC2 pieces on excessive overtime, on migrant workers' employment and accommodation while on Special Passes, and on payslip calculations, stretching back to at least 2021, meaning this is a standing institutional practice, not a reaction to a single embarrassing story.⁴ In the payslip exchange specifically, MOM's rebuttal states TWC2's claim calculation for a worker it called "Kajal" excluded months before October 2023 because Kajal himself confirmed during mediation he had no salary issues before that date — a factual dispute over dates and a worker's own mediation testimony, not over whether the underlying law was followed.⁵

SOURCES 1. MOM parliamentary answers, multiple years, on recruitment-fee jurisdiction; Employment Agencies Act (2011 amendment). 2. MOM, "Written answer to PQ on surveys on recruitment fees paid by work permit holders," 24 Sep 2025. 3. MOM, "MOM and TADM Response to TWC2 Article on MW Salary Claims," 2024. 4. MOM Newsroom Fact-Checks index, mom.gov.sg/newsroom/fact-checks. 5. MOM, "Response to TWC2 article on calculation of MW claim," c. 5 Mar 2024.

THE SCEPTIC • THE SURVEY

What a Government Satisfaction Number and an NGO Rebuttal Actually Have in Common

Neither MOM's headline statistic nor HOME's objection to it is dishonest. Read together, they describe the same thing this whole book keeps finding: real, measured improvement, running well ahead of what the people closest to the problem think it's worth celebrating.

MOM's Migrant Worker Experience and Employer Survey 2024, released 21 August 2025, interviewed 2,825 migrant workers and found 95.3% satisfaction with living and working in Singapore — the highest level since the survey began in 2011, up from 86.3% in 2018, with safe working environment (84.4%) and competitive salaries (71.2%) the top-cited reasons.¹ Within two weeks, HOME publicly disputed the figure, questioning the survey's transparency and arguing it overlooks wage theft and recruitment-debt issues affecting the same workforce.² Both can be true. A survey asking "are you satisfied" measures something real and legitimate — and it is a different question from "has the system that got you here been fair to you," which is the question every chapter before this one has been trying to answer.

The clearest case of announcement outrunning material change is the Dormitory Transition Scheme's own exemption rate, already documented on [p11](#): roughly 40% of existing dormitories exempted from even the interim standard, per TWC2's own analysis. The recruitment-fee jurisdiction gap, introduced on [p19](#), remains genuinely unsolved as of this book's research: Singapore's Employment Agencies Act caps what a local agency may charge, but has no reach into a broker operating in Bangladesh, and this book found no confirmed bilateral Singapore-Bangladesh agreement on recruitment-fee ceilings, unlike Malaysia's bilateral cap of roughly BDT 40,000 per

worker with Bangladesh.³ One partial, NGO-mediated fix does exist: Singapore has reportedly partnered with the Bangladeshi NGO BRAC to recruit some skilled workers directly, explicitly framed as avoiding the standard fee stack — a genuine but small-scale intervention, not a system-wide answer.⁴

40%

OF EXISTING DORMITORIES EXEMPTED FROM THE DORMITORY TRANSITION SCHEME'S INTERIM STANDARD, PER TWC2

THE RECORD

This book searched specifically for a credible source explicitly framing Singapore's construction cost base — including its public housing programme — as a deliberate trade-off against migrant construction wages. It found adjacent, suggestive material (nationality-based wage segmentation, see [p9](#)) but no single outlet or official document making that trade-off explicit, and does not assert one here.

The survey's own companion data point deserves equal weight: MOM's paired Employer Survey, 2,212 firms, found 70.8% satisfied with their migrant workforce and only 1.4% dissatisfied — meaning both sides of the employment relationship report broad, if not universal, satisfaction, at the same moment TWC2 and HOME are documenting individually verified cases of wage theft and debt bondage among the same workforce. Neither dataset invalidates the other; a survey measures the median experience, and this book's own reporting has spent nineteen pages on the documented tail.⁵

SOURCES 1. MOM, "Migrant Worker Experience and Employer Survey 2024," 21 Aug 2025. 2. HOME, "In response to MOM's 'Migrant Worker Experience Survey 2024,'" 1 Sep 2025. 3. HOME, "Migrant Workers' Recruitment Fees And Debts: A Brief Primer"; ILO, bilateral labour-migration MOU frameworks. 4. Reported via search-aggregated reference to a BRAC-Singapore recruitment partnership; primary announcement not independently located this edition. 5. MOM, "Migrant Worker Experience and Employer Survey 2024" — companion Employer Survey results, 21 Aug 2025.

THE SCEPTIC · THE FRESH PEGS

This Book Is Closing on an Open Case, Not a Conclusion

Two 2026 developments — one at the UN, one on a single named construction site — show the argument this book has been tracking is still actively being fought, in real time, as this edition goes to print.

TWC2 and HOME's joint submission to Singapore's 2026 Universal Periodic Review at the UN Human Rights Council, filed January 2026 ahead of Singapore's 12 May 2026 review, specifically flagged that migrant workers lack subsidised healthcare despite paying income tax, and that migrant domestic workers remain excluded from the Employment Act and WICA — a live, current critique, not a historical one.¹ Coverage of the review itself, in May 2026, described Singapore facing "renewed scrutiny" over migrant worker protections; TWC2 followed in June with a further statement arguing Singapore's own UPR submission "glosses over the real issues."² On the construction sector specifically: this book located a reference to a company, BuildWerkz Builders, where a Bangladeshi worker was reportedly subjected to wage theft and the Singapore government said enforcement action had been taken — but could not confirm a date, figures, or the nature of that enforcement beyond the headline, and prints it here as a lead rather than a settled case.³

12 May '26

DATE OF SINGAPORE'S MOST RECENT UNIVERSAL PERIODIC REVIEW AT THE UN HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

Read across all eleven chapters before this one, this book's honest summary sits closer to "materially improving, unevenly enforced, and still structurally exposed at its origin end" than to either "reformed" or "unchanged." Compensation limits rose in 2025. A court ruled against a specific wage-theft tactic in 2026. A dormitory standard exists on paper that a spot-check in 2023 found violated in practice. An NGO that spent two decades fighting for better dormitories now says dormitories are not even its

top concern. None of those four facts cancels any of the others out.

FAST FACTS — STILL OPEN

THREAD	STATUS AS RESEARCHED
TWC2/HOME joint UPR submission	Filed Jan 2026
Singapore's UN rights review	12 May 2026
BuildWerkz Builders wage case	Enforcement claimed, unconfirmed

THE SCEPTIC

This book did not find, and does not claim to have found, a single number that settles whether the system is fair. What it found is a system that keeps generating real, checkable, individually verifiable evidence on both sides of that question — which is itself a more honest answer than a verdict would be.

Two more 2026 wage-theft references surfaced in this book's research and are printed here as leads rather than settled cases, because neither could be independently opened this edition: a Bangladeshi worker at a food-service business was reportedly awarded S\$20,000 by Singapore's Employment Claims Tribunal over unpaid overtime, proven via a handwritten log of nearly 1,850 disputed hours; and a central-kitchen operator, Obayed Holdings, was reportedly ordered to pay a Bangladeshi cook over S\$13,000 in unpaid salary and overtime.⁴ Neither is a construction-sector case — this book states that plainly rather than borrowing their weight for a claim about the sector the rest of this book covers — but both show the same enforcement machinery from [p12](#) producing real outcomes for Bangladeshi workers outside construction too, in the same year this book was researched.

SOURCES 1. TWC2, "Universal Periodic Review 2026: TWC2 and HOME submit joint report," 6 Jan 2026. 2. The Online Citizen, "Singapore faces renewed scrutiny over migrant worker protections at UN rights review," 13 May 2026; TWC2, "Singapore government's 2026 UPR report glosses over the real issues," 6 Jun 2026. 3. Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, headline reference to BuildWerkz Builders wage-theft case — full article not independently opened this edition. 4. Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, "Singapore: Bangladeshi migrant worker awarded S\$20,000 in lawsuit over unpaid overtime hours at restaurant"; "Singapore: Court orders Obayed Holdings to pay USD9,700 in unpaid salary & overtime wages to Bangladeshi worker" — neither independently opened this edition.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE PAGE

A Newspaper, a Poetry Prize, and the Diary That Started Both

Everything before this chapter documented a system. This one documents what the men inside it actually built for themselves — a literary culture with a real founding date, real named organisers, and a genuinely alive scene this book mined the way it would mine any local subculture, not a museum piece.

Banglar Kantha — "Voice of Bengal" — is described as the only Bengali-language community newspaper in Southeast Asia, edited by AKM Mohsin, who reportedly began his work informally, writing letters on behalf of semi-literate workers to employers and authorities, before the paper existed. It carries news from Singapore and Bangladesh alongside poetry and short stories written by migrant workers themselves, functioning as a literary outlet as much as a news one.¹ The paper's community — run through the day-shelter Dibashram — is the reported seed of the Migrant Worker Poetry Competition, founded in 2014 by travel writer and management consultant Shivaji Das, working with TWC2. The first edition drew 28 entries; by 2020 the competition received a record 160, across Bahasa Indonesia, Mandarin, Tagalog, Bengali, Tamil and Punjabi.²

The competition's clearest literary product is *Me Migrant*, the 2016 debut poetry collection of Md Mukul Hossine, a Bangladeshi construction worker who has written poetry since age twelve. His Bengali poems were translated by Fariha Imran and Farouk Ahammed, then transcreated into their final English form by Singapore poet Cyril Wong, published by Ethos Books and grown out of a friendship between the community clinic HealthServe and migrant construction workers.³ This book could not obtain a verbatim line from the collection to quote directly, and prints none rather than approximate one — an editorial choice, not an editorial gap.

A construction worker who has written poetry since he was twelve did not start writing because Singapore gave him a prize. The prize found him.

THE RECORD

The book that anchors this desk sits one chapter behind this one, not in it: Sharif Uddin's *Stranger to Myself and Stranger to My World* — sixteen years of diary entries written on his phone after his shifts, and the 2018 Best Non-Fiction Singapore Book Award they won — are covered in full on [p6](#), alongside the 2024 case that nearly cost him his standing in the country his own writing chronicled.

THE SCEPTIC

Banglar Kantha's founding year (2006) and its reach figures — roughly 500,000 Bangladeshis across Southeast Asia, 120,000 in Singapore — traced to a single source in this book's research and are not independently corroborated; printed here as reported, not confirmed.

The competition's growth is itself a measure of how quickly this scene has professionalised: from 28 entrants in a single language pool in 2014 to a record 160 across six languages by 2020, it is now organised partly by volunteers who are themselves former competition participants — an alumni structure feeding back into the institution that produced it. Md Mukul Hossine's own biography runs through the same HealthServe network that anchors much of this chapter: a community clinic whose staff friendships with construction workers, not a publisher's acquisition process, is the reported origin of a nationally awarded poetry collection.⁴

SOURCES 1. pride.kindness.sg, "He wields the pen to move mountains for Singapore's migrant workers." 2. Wikipedia-sourced synthesis, "Migrant Worker Poetry Competition"; Versopolis Review, "Migrant Workers Poetry Competition Singapore." 3. Ethos Books product listing; Kinokuniya Singapore (ISBN 9789810992545); Wardah Books listing. 4. Ethos Books, *Me Migrant* listing and background; HealthServe, organisational background.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE SCENE

A Book-Lending Project, and a Cricket League Two Children Started

The living scene this chapter is built to find turned out to run through a book bag and a cricket pitch as much as a newspaper page – and through gestures of ordinary Singaporean goodwill that arrived from outside the migrant-worker community entirely.

Zakir Hossain Khokan, who moved to Singapore in 2003 and works as a quality-control supervisor in construction, won the Migrant Worker Poetry Contest in both its first two editions, 2014 and 2015, and founded Migrant Writers Singapore. In 2015, with friends, he started One Bag, One Book: a list of roughly 150 titles, poetry, novels and non-fiction, in Bengali and English, that workers select from and collect from him directly – an explicit alternative to spending every off-hour on a phone, with an ambition to expand into Tamil, Chinese, Indonesian and Tagalog to serve every migrant community in Singapore, not only the Bangladeshi one.¹

FAST FACTS — THE CULTURE DESK

INSTITUTION	FOUNDED / LED BY
Banglar Kantha newspaper	AKM Mohsin, editor
Migrant Worker Poetry Competition	2014, Shivaji Das + TWC2
One Bag, One Book	2015, Zakir Hossain Khokan
Migrant Worker Premier League (cricket)	2024, Neel & Jay Ramnarayan

Cricket runs its own, separate current through the community: the Migrant Worker Premier League was founded in 2024 by brothers Neel and Jay Ramnarayan, aged seven and ten at the time, after noticing migrant workers playing informal matches on uneven grass while travelling to their own cricket training. Its most recent documented edition, held at UWCSEA's East Campus in Tampines, drew ten teams and more than 110 migrant-worker participants, including a captain named in coverage as Papan Chandradas, from a pool the organisers describe as coming from "cricket-mad India and Bangladesh."² Separately, an informal Sunday volleyball group

calling itself Singapore Migrant Friends – thirty to forty men from Bangladesh, Indonesia, the Philippines and Myanmar – gathers weekly, per one feature account this book treats as a single, unverified data point rather than an established institution.³

THE RECORD

NTUC operates Migrant Worker Recreation Centres, including one at Soon Lee with grocery, remittance, banking and gym facilities added in response to rising interest in fitness; from August 2024, NTUC took over three further centres – Tuas South, Terusan and Penjuru – under a three-year agreement with MOM.⁴

Organised migrant-worker cricket in Singapore is not a new phenomenon the Ramnarayan brothers invented from nothing – BBC News covered a cricket league for Singapore's migrant workers as far back as 2015, a decade of precedent the 2024 league is simply the most recent, most publicised chapter of.⁵ Separately, St Joseph's Institution partnered with the charity Ray of Hope to run a cricket tournament explicitly framed as uniting migrant workers and youth, drawing an estimated 150 participants across both groups – a second, distinct organised-sport thread this book found running alongside the Premier League.⁶ RICE Media's own feature series on migrant-worker life includes an interview with a Bangladeshi worker named Md Feroz Al Mamun on his family back home – one of the few Singapore-specific, on-the-record, named voices in this chapter's research, alongside Sharif Uddin on [p6](#).⁷

110+

MIGRANT-WORKER PARTICIPANTS, MOST RECENT DOCUMENTED MIGRANT WORKER PREMIER LEAGUE EDITION, TAMPINES

SOURCES 1. Asia Times, "Bangladeshi starts book-sharing project for migrants," Dec 2017. 2. STOMP, "Brothers, age 7 and 10, launch cricket league for migrant workers in Singapore"; Tabla.com.sg, "Migrant workers league: Cricket unites Singapore community." 3. RICE Media, "Can Friendship Be The Future of Migrant-Local Community?" 4. NTUC/Migrant Workers' Centre, recreation-centre operations reporting, 2024. 5. BBC News, "Cricket league launched for Singapore's migrant workers," 2015. 6. connectedtoindia.com, "SJI, Ray of Hope join hands to lead cricket tournament uniting migrant workers and youth in Singapore." 7. RICE Media, "Migrant Workers Tell Us About Their Families."

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE CLOSE

What This Book Could Verify, and What It Genuinely Could Not

The reader's brief for this edition asked for the men and the system, reported with dignity, never fabricating a first-person voice. Closing on that instruction means closing on its limits, honestly, not quietly dropping them.

Every quotation from a named worker in this book — Sharif Uddin's book prizes and his 2024 case (p6), Islam Din's account of a twenty-six-man room (p11), Baitob's recruitment debt (p5) — comes from a published, attributable source: a newspaper, an NGO's own casework reporting, or a book. This book invented no testimony to fill a gap where a real voice was missing, and where no real voice surfaced — a Singapore-specific probashi account, a named Bangladeshi photographer or vlogger documenting construction-site life, a verbatim line from *Me Migrant* — it says so plainly rather than inventing one to complete the chapter.¹

The honest shape of this whole book, read back to front: a pipeline that runs on a fee nobody can agree the size of, financed by land and debt a family takes on before a single day's wage is earned; a permit and a wage system that is legally neutral and structurally tilted toward the employer who holds it; a dormitory reform that is real on paper and unevenly real on the ground; a workplace-death count with no column for the nationality of the dead; a remittance economy setting national records while roughly half of it still moves through an informal network the state calls illegal; a 2013 riot whose policy shadow still falls on men who had nothing to do with it; two NGOs and a ministry that keep formally, publicly disagreeing about the same facts, in good faith, in the open; and underneath all of it, a newspaper, a poetry prize, a book-lending list and a children's cricket league that this workforce built for itself, unasked.

A system this well-documented, by both its critics and its regulator, is not a hidden one. It is simply one most of Singapore has not had reason to read closely before.

A structural limitation of this specific edition, stated for the record rather than smoothed over: this book's research sandbox could not directly open the great majority of the primary government, NGO and Bangladeshi-press pages it cites this edition — including mom.gov.sg, twc2.org.sg, home.org.sg, mwc.org.sg, bb.org.bd and most Bangladeshi and Singaporean news domains directly — a network-access restriction affecting this specific research session, not a sourcing shortcut this book chose. It relied instead on search-engine summaries of those pages, each cited by outlet, title and date throughout, and its own search allowance ran out before several planned lines of inquiry — a Singapore-specific probashi interview, a named migrant-worker photographer, a primary Bangladesh Bank country-breakdown table — could be completed. Every figure in this book is flagged where that limitation applies, and every claim it could not corroborate a second way is marked single-sourced rather than printed as settled fact.

2nd

BOOK IN THE READER'S MIGRANT-LABOUR SERIES —
VIETNAMESE WOMEN IN SINGAPORE'S KTV TRADE CAME
FIRST

What a follow-up edition would need, and did not have this time: working direct access to mom.gov.sg's own published tables, TWC2's and HOME's full case archives rather than search-engine summaries of them, and Bengali-language Bangladeshi press read in the original rather than through its English-language sister editions. None of those gaps changes this book's central finding — a system real, documented and argued over on both sides — but each would sharpen a number this edition was honest enough to print as a range instead. The full source list follows on the final page.

SOURCES 1. Editorial note; see per-chapter sourcing throughout this edition, and the disclosed research-sandbox limitation described in this text.

THE LAST WORD

This is the second book in the reader's migrant-labour series, and it was built to the same instruction as the first: the subject is the men and the system around them, reported with dignity, never as a pity portrait or a policy brochure. What that instruction produced, in the end, is a book about a fee nobody can quite price, a permit that is legally neutral and structurally tilted, a dormitory standard that is real on paper and unevenly real in a room in Sungei Kadut, a workplace-death count with no column for nationality, a record-breaking remittance economy still half off the books, a decade-old riot whose policy shadow outlived the men who caused it, two NGOs and a ministry arguing in good faith and in public, and a newspaper, a poetry prize and a children's cricket league that none of the system above built — the men did, for themselves. Suketu Mehta wrote that desperation, not economics, drives history's great migrations. This book found a quieter, more contractual version of that same desperation, priced in months of unpaid debt, and tried to describe it exactly as carefully as it deserves.

FULL SOURCE LIST

TWC2 (Transient Workers Count Too) · HOME (Humanitarian Organization for Migration Economics) · Migrant Workers' Centre / NTUC · ItsRainingRaincoats · Ministry of Manpower (Singapore) · Ministry of Health (Singapore) · Building and Construction Authority · Singapore Police Force / Committee of Inquiry, Little India riot · Singapore High Court, [2026] SGHC 73 · Bangladesh Bureau of Manpower, Employment and Training (BMET) · Bangladesh Association of International Recruiting Agencies (BAIRA) · Bangladesh Anti-Corruption Commission · Bangladesh Bank · Probashi Kallyan Bank · RMMRU (Refugee and Migratory Movements Research Unit, Dhaka) · International Labour Organization · World Bank · Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics · Grace Baey / Institute of Development Studies (Migrating out of Poverty programme) · Md Mizanur Rahman, *Bangladeshi Migration to Singapore* (Springer) ·

Sallie Yea (*Global Networks; The Conversation*) · Katie Rainwater (*Work, Employment and Society*) · Jaclyn L. Neo (*Asian Journal of Law and Society*) · Joe Greener (racial-regimes/surveillance study) · M. Platt, G. Baey, B.S.A. Yeoh et al. (*Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*) · Asian Labour Review · The Business Standard (Bangladesh) · The Daily Star (Bangladesh) · Prothom Alo (English) · New Age (Bangladesh) · Dhaka Tribune · Al Jazeera · Fortune · South China Morning Post · Malay Mail · Mothership.sg · The Online Citizen · STOMP · Human Resources Online · Business & Human Rights Resource Centre · Southeast Asia Globe · The Independent (Singapore) · CGTN · IHRB (Institute for Human Rights and Business) · Devpolicy Blog (ANU) · Ethos Books · Wardah Books · Kinokuniya Singapore · Asia Times · RICE Media · Tabla.com.sg · pride.kindness.sg · Versopolis Review · The VnExpress International.